
The Writing Bank

The words. Organised by the job,
not by the chart type.

Do not read this. Look things up in it. Task 1 language, Task 2 language, and every grammar structure with the one error you personally make in it. The index on the next page tells you where to go when you are stuck.

THE WRITING BANKS

Do not read these. Look things up in them.

The moves you just read are what you *do*. What follows is the language you use to do it — organised by the job, not by the chart type.

How to use them

When	Go to
<i>You need to compare two figures</i>	Task 1 bank → §10 Comparison
<i>A number went up and you've already written "increased" twice</i>	Task 1 bank → §3 and §8
<i>You don't know what tense to use</i>	Task 1 bank → §14
<i>You got a process or a map</i>	Task 1 bank → §15 or §16
<i>You're staring at a Task 2 question and have no ideas</i>	Task 2 bank → §17 Idea banks
<i>You need to disagree without sounding rude</i>	Task 2 bank → §10 Concede-then-counter
<i>Your sentence sounds too absolute</i>	Task 2 bank → §11 Hedging
<i>You need a structure and can't remember the pattern</i>	Grammar on demand

Before your test, read only two things here: the **comparison** section, because the official Task 1 instruction demands comparisons, and the **concede-then-counter** frames, because that single move is what makes a Task 2 argument look mature.

Everything else is for when you are stuck mid-drill.

TASK 1 — the language bank

Everything here is meant to be lifted and used. [X] marks a slot you fill. ⚠ marks an item that is easy to get wrong — one word of warning follows it.

1. Paraphrasing the prompt

One sentence. Change the **verb**, the **noun for the visual**, and the **noun for the data**. Keep every fact.

The verb swap

Prompt says	You write
shows	illustrates · depicts · presents · sets out · gives · provides
gives information about	compares · charts · tracks · traces · documents
shows changes	traces the changes in · charts the development of
compares	draws a comparison between · sets [A] against [B]
shows how X is made	outlines the stages by which [X] is produced
shows a place at two dates	records how [X] changed between [1985] and [2010]

The visual-noun swap

the graph

→ the line graph · the chart · the figure

the bar chart

→ the bar chart · the graph · the chart

the pie chart

→ the pie chart · the two pie charts · the charts

the table

→ the table · the figures · the data

the diagram

→ the diagram · the illustration · the flow chart

(process only) the map

→ the two maps · the plans · the two plans of [Ashcombe]

⚠ Never write *the given graph* / *the above chart* — memorised-phrase flag.

The data-noun swap

Prompt word	Replacements
information	data · figures · statistics
numbers	figures · totals · levels
percentages	proportions · shares · percentage figures
spending	expenditure · outlay · the amount spent on
people who	the proportion of people who · [X] users · those who
money	expenditure · income · revenue · cost
how many	the number of · levels of · the volume of

10 ready patterns

1. The line graph illustrates changes in [X] in [three countries] between [1990] and [2010].
2. The bar chart compares [X] across [five categories] in [2022].
3. The two pie charts show how [X] was divided in [2010] and in [2025].
4. The table sets out figures for [X] in [three countries] over a [twenty-year] period.
5. The diagram outlines the process by which [glass bottles] are [recycled].
6. The two maps show how [Ashcombe] changed between [1985] and the present day.
7. The graph traces the development of [X] over a period of [two decades].
8. The chart provides a breakdown of [household waste] by [source].
9. The diagram depicts two alternative designs of [a hand-operated well pump].
10. The figures compare [X] and [Y] in terms of [Z].

⚠ The chart is about... — too informal. Use a verb from the table.

2. Signalling the overview

Two sentences. **No figures.** Begin with one of these.

- Overall, ... ← the safe default, use it
- Overall, it is clear that ...
- It is immediately apparent that ...
- The most striking feature is that ...
- The most noticeable trend is that ...
- The dominant pattern is that ...
- Broadly, the data fall into two groups: ...

- *In general terms, ...*
- *What stands out is that ...*
- *Taken as a whole, the figures show that ...*

Second overview sentence – the add-on: - *The second point of note is that ...* - *A further point of interest is that ...* - *[X], by contrast, ...* - *The only category to buck this pattern was [X].*

⚠ *In conclusion / To sum up* – never in Task 1. There is no conclusion. ⚠ *We can see that / I can observe that* – wrong register. Delete.

3. Going up

Verbs (intransitive – nothing after them but an adverb or a preposition)

Weak → strong
<i>edge up · inch up · creep up</i>
<i>rise · increase · grow · go up</i>
<i>climb · advance · escalate</i>
<i>surge · jump · leap · shoot up</i>
<i>rocket · soar · skyrocket</i>

Nouns

a rise · an increase · growth · an upward trend · an upturn · a climb · a surge · a jump · a leap · an escalation · a boom

With adverbs (verb + adverb)

rose slightly · rose gradually · rose steadily · climbed steadily · increased significantly · grew substantially · rose sharply · surged dramatically

Other useful shapes

- *[X] showed an upward trend.*
- *[X] was on the rise throughout the period.*
- *[X] followed an upward path.*
- *[X] more than doubled.*
- *There was a marked upturn in [X].*
- *[X] saw considerable growth.*
- *[X] recorded its strongest growth between [1995] and [2000].*

⚠ *was increased* – wrong. *rise, fall, increase, decrease, grow, decline* are intransitive. ✗ *the number was increased* → ✓ *the number increased*. ⚠ *raise* is a different verb and needs an object: ✗ *sales*

raised → ✓ *sales rose*. ⚠ *augmented* (French) → ✓ *rose* · *increased*. ⚠ *skyrocketed* / *rocketed* — only for a genuinely explosive rise. Wrong size = TA error.

4. Going down

Verbs

Weak → strong
<i>dip</i> · <i>edge down</i> · <i>slip</i> · <i>ease</i>
<i>fall</i> · <i>decrease</i> · <i>decline</i> · <i>drop</i> · <i>go down</i> · <i>reduce</i> (no object → use <i>fall</i>)
<i>sink</i> · <i>slide</i> · <i>shrink</i> · <i>contract</i>
<i>plunge</i> · <i>slump</i> · <i>tumble</i> · <i>dive</i>
<i>plummet</i> · <i>collapse</i> · <i>crash</i>

Nouns

a fall · a decrease · a decline · a drop · a dip · a downturn · a reduction · a slump · a plunge · a collapse · a downward trend

With adverbs

fell slightly · dipped marginally · declined gradually · fell steadily · dropped noticeably · fell sharply · plunged dramatically

Other useful shapes

- *[X] showed a downward trend.*
- *[X] was in decline over the period.*
- *[X] halved / fell by half.*
- *[X] fell back to its [1990] level.*
- *There was a steady decline in [X].*
- *[X] saw the steepest fall of any category.*
- *[X] lost ground throughout the period.*

⚠ *diminution* (French) → ✓ *decline* · *drop* · *fall*. ⚠ *decreased strongly* — wrong collocation → ✓ *decreased sharply* · *fell steeply*. ⚠ *plummeted* for a 3% fall is an accuracy error, not just a lexical one. ⚠ *reduce* needs an object (*the plant reduces waste*). For a bare fall use *fall*.

5. No change / stability

Verbs

remain stable · remain steady · remain constant · remain unchanged · stay the same · hold steady · stand at · level off · plateau · flatten out · stabilise · show little change · change little · vary little

Nouns / adjectives

stability · no significant change · a period of stability · stable · steady · constant · unchanged · flat · static

Ready sentences

- *[X] remained stable at around [5 million] throughout the period.*
- *[X] showed almost no change over the two decades.*
- *[X] held steady at [40 per cent].*
- *[X] levelled off after [2005] and changed little thereafter.*
- *[X] stood at [200] in both years.*
- *There was no appreciable change in [X].*
- *[X] was the one category to remain untouched.*
- *[X] fluctuated slightly but ended the period roughly where it began.*

⚠ *level off* and *plateau* mean **stopped rising** — not *fell*. Using them for a fall is a factual error. ⚠
preposition: *remained stable at 5 million* — not *stable to*.

6. Fluctuation and irregular movement

Verbs

fluctuate · vary · oscillate · swing · waver · move erratically · rise and fall · go up and down

Nouns

fluctuation · variation · volatility · an erratic pattern · ups and downs

Ready sentences

- *[X] fluctuated between [40] and [60] over the period.*
- *[X] fluctuated wildly / slightly / considerably before settling at [X].*
- *[X] followed an erratic course, with no clear overall direction.*
- *After a period of volatility, [X] settled at around [50].*
- *[X] rose and fell repeatedly, ending the period close to its starting figure.*
- *[X] showed considerable year-on-year variation.*

Adverbs that fit: wildly · erratically · considerably · slightly · sharply

△ *fluctuate* is intransitive: ✗ *was fluctuated* → ✓ *fluctuated*. △ preposition: *fluctuated between X and Y*, *fluctuated around 50*.

7. Peaks, lows and turning points

Highs

- *[X] peaked at [11 million] in [2004].*
- *[X] reached a peak of [11 million].*
- *[X] reached a high of [11 million].*
- *[X] hit its highest point in [2004].*
- *[X] reached its maximum in [2004], at [11 million].*
- *[X] climbed to an all-time high of [11 million].*
- *The peak came in [2004].*

Lows

- *[X] bottomed out at [2 million] in [1998].*
- *[X] reached a low of [2 million].*
- *[X] fell to its lowest point in [1998].*
- *[X] hit a trough in [1998].*
- *[X] reached a record low.*

Turning points and reversals

- *[X] rose until [2000], after which it began to fall.*
- *[X] reversed direction in [2000].*
- *The trend was reversed after [2000].*
- *[X] recovered / rebounded / picked up after [2000].*
- *[X] fell back sharply from its peak.*
- *[X] resumed its upward path in [2005].*
- *[X] overtook [Y] around the midpoint of the period.*
- *The two lines crossed in [2005].*

Flattening

- *[X] levelled off at around [50].*
- *[X] plateaued for the remainder of the period.*
- *Growth tailed off after [2010].*

△ **the preposition split**: *peaked at 11 million* (verb) but *a peak of 11 million* (noun). ✗ *peaked to* · ✗ *a peak at*. △ *bottomed out* means it stopped falling — it does not mean it rose.

8. Degree and speed of change

Two separate scales. You need the **adverb** (goes with a verb) and the **adjective** (goes with a noun) of each.

DEGREE — how big

Size	Adverb (verb + adv)	Adjective (a ... rise)
tiny	marginally · minimally · negligibly	marginal · minimal · negligible
small	slightly · a little · modestly	slight · small · modest
moderate	moderately · noticeably · appreciably	moderate · noticeable · appreciable
large	significantly · substantially · considerably · markedly	significant · substantial · considerable · marked
very large	dramatically · sharply · steeply · drastically · enormously	dramatic · sharp · steep · drastic · enormous

SPEED — how fast

Speed	Adverb	Adjective
slow, even	gradually · steadily · progressively · slowly	gradual · steady · progressive · slow
brisk	quickly · rapidly · swiftly	quick · rapid · swift
instant	suddenly · abruptly · overnight	sudden · abrupt

Combining both: *rose steadily but substantially* · *a sudden, marked increase* · *fell gradually at first and then sharply*.

△ *significative* is not an English word → ✓ *significant*. △ *an important increase* (French *importante*) → ✓ *a substantial increase*. △ *strongly* does not collocate with rise/fall → ✓ *sharply* · *steeply*. △ *hardly* ≠ *slightly*. *Hardly rose* = almost no rise at all.

9. THE TWO GRAMMAR SHAPES — alternate these

Same fact, two structures. Use both in every report. This is the cheapest Grammatical Range point in Task 1.

Shape 1 — verb + adverb	Shape 2 — there was a + adjective + noun
<i>Car use rose sharply.</i>	<i>There was a sharp rise in car use.</i>
<i>Sales fell steadily between 1990 and 2000.</i>	<i>There was a steady fall in sales between 1990 and 2000.</i>
<i>Cycling declined marginally.</i>	<i>There was a marginal decline in cycling.</i>
<i>Expenditure grew dramatically after 2005.</i>	<i>There was a dramatic growth in expenditure after 2005.</i>
<i>Attendance fluctuated considerably.</i>	<i>There was considerable fluctuation in attendance.</i>

Two further shapes worth owning:

- **Change as subject:** *The steepest decline occurred between [1995] and [2000]. · The sharpest rise came in [2004]. · The biggest change was in [X].*
- **[X] saw / experienced / underwent:** *[Germany] saw a sharp rise in [X]. · [The sector] experienced a marked decline.*
- **Participle clause:** *Sales climbed steadily, rising to a peak of [40%] before falling back.*

⚠ preposition after the noun: *a rise in sales* — not *a rise of sales* (*a rise of 7 million* means the size of the rise).

10. COMPARISON — the biggest section

The rubric demands it: *make comparisons where relevant*. On any visual with no time axis, this section replaces §3–§8 entirely.

10.1 Comparatives

Form: one syllable

→ -er

(higher, lower, larger, smaller, faster, greater). Two syllables ending -y

→ -ier

(heavier, steadier). Otherwise

→ more

+ adjective (more expensive, more common, more significant).

The workhorses

higher than · lower than · greater than · larger than · smaller than · more common than · less common than · more popular than · faster than · steeper than · more pronounced than · more marked than

Intensified — put an adverb in front of the comparative

Big gap	Small gap
far higher than	slightly higher than
significantly higher than	marginally higher than
considerably higher than	a little higher than
substantially higher than	somewhat higher than
markedly higher than	fractionally higher than
well above / well below	just above / just below
nowhere near as high as	almost as high as

Ready sentences

- *[A] was significantly higher than [B] in every year.*
- *Spending on [X] was far greater than on [Y].*
- *[A] recorded a considerably steeper rise than [B].*
- *The figure for [A] was only marginally lower than that for [B].*
- *[A] was well above the average for the group.*
- *The gap between [A] and [B] widened / narrowed over the period.*

The errors – one line each

- ✗ *more higher* → ✓ **much higher · far higher**
- ✗ *more bigger* → ✓ **far bigger**
- ✗ *most highest* → ✓ **the highest**
- ✗ *higher that [B] (French que)* → ✓ **higher than [B]**
- ✗ *more high* → ✓ **higher**
- ✗ *the most big* → ✓ **the biggest**
- ✗ *[A] is more high than [B] of 20%* → ✓ **[A] is 20% higher than [B]**
- ✗ *very higher* → ✓ **much higher**
- ✗ *[A] is superior to [B] (French supérieur à)* → ✓ **[A] is higher than [B]**
- ✗ *[A] is inferior to [B]* → ✓ **[A] is lower than [B]**

10.2 Superlatives

the highest · the lowest · the largest · the smallest · the greatest · the most common · the least common · the most popular · the least popular

Ranking inside a superlative

- *the second highest · the third largest · the second most common*
- *the next highest · the next largest*
- *by far the largest · easily the highest · comfortably the lowest*
- *the highest of the five · the highest of any country shown*

- *the single largest category*
- *[X] recorded the highest figure, at [210 litres].*
- *[X] was the least popular option, chosen by only [8 per cent].*
- *At the other end of the scale, [X] accounted for just [4 per cent].*

△ *the* is compulsory with a superlative: ✗ *[A] was highest* → ✓ *[A] was the highest*. (*[A] was highest in 2010* is acceptable only where you mean "at its own highest".) △ ✗ *the more high* · ✗ *the most highest*. △ ✗ *the second the highest* → ✓ *the second highest*.

10.3 Multiples and ratios

Meaning	Say it like this
×2	<i>twice as many as · twice as much as · double the figure for [B] · [A] is double [B]</i>
×3	<i>three times as many as · three times higher than · treble the number of</i>
×10	<i>ten times as many as · a tenfold increase</i>
×½	<i>half as many as · half as much as · half the figure for [B]</i>
×⅓	<i>a third as many as · a third of the figure for [B]</i>
growth ×2	<i>doubled · more than doubled · nearly doubled</i>
growth ×3	<i>trebled · tripled</i>
fall ×½	<i>halved · fell by half</i>
open-ended	<i>more than twice as many as · over three times higher than · upwards of four times</i>

Ready sentences

- *[A] used more than twice as much water per head as [C].*
- *The figure for [A] was three times that for [B].*
- *[A] was double the figure recorded in [B].*
- *There was a fivefold difference between the highest and lowest figures.*
- *[X] rose tenfold over the period.*
- *For every [one] person who [X], [three] chose [Y].*
- *The ratio of [A] to [B] was roughly two to one.*

△ ✗ *twice more than* (French *deux fois plus que*) → ✓ **twice as many as**. △ ✗ *three times more high* → ✓ **three times higher**. △ **countable vs uncountable**: *as many as* + plural count (*as many cars as*); *as much as* + uncountable (*as much water as*). △ *twice as many as* takes **as**, not *than*: ✗ *twice as many than*. △ Check the arithmetic before you write the multiple. $185 \div 90 = 2.06$ is *just over twice*, not *well over twice*.

10.4 Equality and similarity

as high as · as many as · as much as · the same as · identical to · comparable to · comparable with
· on a par with · roughly equal to · broadly similar to · at a similar level to · close to

Adverbs and linkers

similarly · likewise · equally · in the same way · correspondingly · in both cases · in each of the
[three] countries

Both / neither

- *Both [A] and [B] rose over the period.*
- *[A] and [B] alike showed a steady increase.*
- *Neither [A] nor [B] changed appreciably.*
- *The same was true of [B].*
- *[B] followed a similar pattern.*
- *[B] mirrored this trend.*
- *[A] and [B] were almost identical, at [40] and [41] respectively.*

△ *as high as [B]* takes **as ... as**: ✗ *as high than* → ✓ *as high as*. △ *the same as*, **not the same **that**, not *the same like*. △ **similar **to**, not *similar with* (**but comparable **to/with** are both fine). △ *Both* takes a plural verb: ✗ *both was* → ✓ *both were*.

10.5 Difference and contrast

Subordinators — inside one sentence

whereas · while · although · even though · despite the fact that

- *[A] rose steadily, whereas [B] moved in the opposite direction.*
- *While [A] climbed, [B] held steady.*
- *Although [B] declined, it remained the second most common mode.*

Sentence linkers — between sentences

By contrast, · In contrast, · Conversely, · On the other hand, · [B], however, · [B], by comparison, ·

Prepositional phrases

compared with [B] · in comparison with [B] · relative to [B] · as against [B] · unlike [B] · in contrast to [B] · as opposed to [B]

Contrast verbs — the band-7 ones

- *[A] outstripped [B] by a wide margin.*
- *[A] outnumbered [B] three to one.*
- *[A] outperformed [B] in every category.*
- *[B] lagged behind [A] throughout.*
- *[B] trailed the other categories.*

- *[B] fell short of [A] by [10] percentage points.*
- *[A] overtook [B] in [2005].*
- *[A] far exceeded [B].*
- *[A] dwarfed the remaining categories.*
- *The gap between [A] and [B] widened to [20] points.*
- *[A] and [B] diverged sharply after [2000].*

Naming the difference

- *The chief difference lies in [X].*
- *The most obvious contrast is between [A] and [B].*
- *[A] differs from [B] in that it [X].*
- *[A] stands apart from the rest of the group.*
- *The sole exception was [X].*

△ *on the other hand*, not *in the other hand*. △ *whereas / while* join two clauses inside one sentence; *however / by contrast* start a new sentence. ✗ *[A] rose, however [B] fell.* → ✓ *[A] rose; however, [B] fell.*
 △ *compared with/to*, **not comparing to**. △ *different **from*, not *different of*. △ *contrary to* is not a synonym of *by contrast*. Use *by contrast* for data.

10.6 Ranking

- *[A] ranked first, followed by [B] and [C].*
- *[A] came first / came second / came bottom.*
- *[A] topped the list, at [210].*
- *[A] headed the table.*
- *[A] took first place, narrowly ahead of [B].*
- *[A] occupied second place.*
- *[B] was the second most popular choice.*
- *[C] came last, with just [40].*
- *[C] was the least popular category by some margin.*
- *At the other end of the scale, [C]...*
- *The remaining [three] categories all fell below [50].*
- *In descending order, the leading categories were [A], [B] and [C].*
- *[A] led on every measure except [X].*

△ *ranked first*, not *ranked at the first place*. △ *the first mode* means the earliest, not the biggest → ✓ *the leading mode*.

11. Proportions, fractions and percentages

Fractions

a quarter · a third · two thirds · three quarters · four fifths · a half · three fifths · a tenth · a fifth

Quantifiers of a whole

the vast majority · a large majority · a small majority · just over half · a significant minority · a small minority · a tiny fraction · a negligible share · the bulk of · the remainder · the rest · the balance

"One in ..."

one in five · one in ten · two in every three · nine out of ten · fewer than one in twenty

Verbs of composition

- *[X] accounted for [34] per cent of the total.*
- *[X] made up [a third] of all [waste].*
- *[X] constituted [the largest] share.*
- *[X] represented [a quarter] of the total.*
- *[X] comprised [three] main categories. ⚠ never comprised of*
- *[X] consisted of [three] elements.*
- *[X] contributed [15] per cent.*
- *[X] took the largest share, at [34] per cent.*
- *[X] was responsible for [a fifth] of the total.*
- *The total was made up of [A], [B] and [C].*
- *[A] and [B] together accounted for well over half.*

Percentage points vs per cent ⚠ 20% → 30% is a rise of **10 percentage points**, or of **50 per cent**. If unsure, write *rose from 20% to 30%* and sidestep it entirely.

⚠ *accounted for* — **not accounted 40%**. ⚠ *a proportion is a part of a whole*: ✗ *the proportion of 5 million* → ✓ *the figure of 5 million*. ⚠ *the number of cars **was* (singular) but *a number of cars were* (plural). ⚠ *the majority of respondents **were* (plural), *the proportion of women was* (singular). ⚠ ✗ *20 per cents* · ✗ *five millions* → ✓ *20 per cent · five million*. ⚠ *percentage needs the or a modifier*: ✗ *percentage of women rose* → ✓ *the percentage of women rose*. ⚠ *On a percentage pie chart you cannot say the number rose* — only the share did.

12. Approximation

BELOW the figure — *nearly · almost · just under · a little under · not quite · close to · approaching · fewer than · under*

ABOVE the figure — *just over · a little over · slightly more than · well over · upwards of · in excess of · more than · over*

EITHER SIDE — *approximately · roughly · around · about · some · in the region of · of the order of · or so · give or take*

Ready sentences

- *just over [40,000] · just under [half]*
- *in the region of [200]*
- *some [15] per cent*
- *upwards of [half]*
- *approximately [one third]*
- *roughly [double] the figure for [B]*
- *well over [half] of all respondents*
- *a figure approaching [90] per cent*
- *between [45] and [50] percentage points*

⚠ **This is the trap: *nearly, almost, just under* mean BELOW the number. *Just over, well over, upwards of* mean ABOVE it.** Putting a figure on the wrong side is a factual error, not a style choice. ⚠ *well over* means *clearly* above. For $2.06\times$ do not write *well over twice*. ⚠ Rotate them. *Approximately* six times is restricted range. ⚠ When one approximation has to cover several figures, check it against the **worst** one — otherwise write a range: *between [45] and [50]*.

13. Time and periods

Spans

over the period · over the two decades · over the twenty years in question · throughout the period · across the whole period · during the [1990s] · between [1990] and [2010] · from [1990] to [2010] · in the years from [1990] to [2010] · for the first [ten] years · over the remainder of the period

Points

in [1990] · in [March] · at the start of the period · at the outset · by [2010] · by the end of the period · at the midpoint · midway through the period · in the final year · as of [2010]

Sequence within a trend

initially · at first · in the early years · in the first decade · thereafter · from that point on · in the years that followed · subsequently · over the following decade · in the closing years · by the end · finally

Rate expressions

annually · per year · year on year · per head · per person · per capita · per household · on a daily basis · a decade-long increase

Ready sentences

- *Over the period as a whole, [X] rose by [7 million].*
- *Between [1990] and [2010], [X] more than doubled.*
- *During the first decade, [X] changed little; thereafter it rose sharply.*
- *By [2010], [X] had overtaken [Y].*
- *In the years that followed, the trend was reversed.*
- *[X] rose throughout, with the exception of a brief dip in [1998].*

⚠ *between 1990 to 2010* → ✓ *between 1990 and 2010 / from 1990 to 2010*. ⚠ *during 20 years* → ✓ *for 20 years · over a 20-year period*. ⚠ *at 1990* → ✓ *in 1990*. ⚠ *since 1990* unless the trend runs to now. *Since* + start point, *for* + length. ⚠ *a twenty-years period* → ✓ *a twenty-year period* (no -s on the modifier). ⚠ *in the 1990's* → ✓ *in the 1990s*.

14. Tense — decide in three seconds

What you see	Tense	Example
Dated past range (1990–2010)	past simple	<i>Car use rose from 4 to 11 million.</i>
Range running to "the present day"	present perfect	<i>Car use has risen steadily.</i>
Undated / typical ("a typical day")	present simple	<i>Most journeys are made by car.</i>
Categorical bars, undated table	present simple	<i>Country A uses more water than Country C.</i>
Projected / future part of the graph	<i>is expected to · is projected to · will</i>	<i>Demand is projected to reach 20 million by 2030.</i>
Man-made process	present simple passive	<i>The glass is crushed into cullet.</i>
Natural cycle	present simple, mostly active	<i>The larva hatches after ten days.</i>
Static diagram, object or device	present simple, mostly active	<i>The handle pivots on a steel pin.</i>
Static diagram of a historical artefact	past simple	<i>The chamber was lined with brick.</i>
Maps: dated past → dated past	past simple passive	<i>A car park was built on the site.</i>
Maps: past → "today" / "now"	present perfect passive	<i>The woodland has been cleared.</i>
Maps: present → proposed / planned	modal passive	<i>A marina will be constructed.</i>

Switch tense at the projection boundary — past/present for the data, future forms only for the dotted part.

⚠ The commonest leak is a relative clause: ✗ *the number of people who use the bus fell* → ✓ *the number of people who used the bus fell*. Keep the tense consistent inside the sentence. ⚠ *Today / now / at present* on a map = present perfect. A **date** (2025) = past simple. Never infer "today" from a recent date.

15. PROCESS DIAGRAMS

Sequencers — rotate, do not head every sentence with one

Start: initially · at the outset · in the first stage · to begin with · the process begins with · the first step involves

Middle: subsequently · following this · next · after this · at this stage · at this point · meanwhile · simultaneously · in the following stage · once [X] has been completed · after [X] has been [collected] · having been [washed]

End: in the final stage · finally · lastly · ultimately · the process ends with · at which point the [bottles] are ready for despatch

Passive forms — vary the shape

Shape	Example
plain passive	<i>The glass is sorted by colour.</i>
passive + adverb	<i>The mixture is then thoroughly heated.</i>
passive + purpose infinitive	<i>The pulp is pressed to remove excess water.</i>
present perfect passive	<i>Once the bricks have been fired, they are packed.</i>
passive after <i>before</i> + -ing	<i>The ore is crushed before being melted.</i>
modal passive	<i>The residue may be recycled into the next batch.</i>
<i>undergo</i> (active but formal)	<i>The material undergoes a second filtration.</i>

Purpose and result

in order to · so as to · so that · with the aim of · for the purpose of · this ensures that · this allows [X] to [Y] · thereby [producing] · resulting in · which results in

Precise process verbs — the LR lever

extracted · quarried · mined · harvested · collected · sorted · graded · washed · rinsed · soaked · crushed · ground · milled · sieved · filtered · separated · blended · mixed · heated · smelted · melted · fired · baked · dried · cooled · cured · annealed · moulded · cast · pressed · rolled · cut · shaped · assembled · sealed · treated · purified · packaged · labelled · stored · transported · distributed · despatched

⚠ Never *put in* · *made* · *done* · *get*. Verb precision is the whole LR score here.

Counting and naming stages

- *The process comprises [seven] distinct stages.*
- *The process consists of [seven] stages, from [collection] to [packaging].*

- *There are [seven] main stages, beginning with [X] and ending with [Y].*
- *The process can be divided into [three] broad phases.*
- *The [first] phase covers [collection and preparation].*

⚠ Counting stages is **not** an overview. Name the **phases**.

Cyclical processes

- *The cycle begins when [X].*
- *This in turn triggers [Y].*
- *..., at which point the cycle begins again.*
- *..., thereby completing the cycle.*
- *The process is continuous, with no fixed end point.*
- *The [salmon] returns to [the river of its birth], and the cycle repeats.*

⚠ A cycle does not *finish*. If a return arrow is drawn on the diagram, do not end with *finally*.

Inputs and outputs

- *The raw material for the process is [used glass].*
- *[Sand] and [soda ash] are added at this stage.*
- *The end product is [a finished bottle].*
- *The by-product, [slag], is removed and discarded.*
- *The waste [water] is fed back into the system.*

16. MAPS

Compass and position

Inside the area	Beyond the edge
in the north · in the northern part	to the north of · north of
in the south-east corner	to the south-east of
in the centre · at the heart of	on the outskirts of · beyond the town

More position language

adjacent to · next to · alongside · beside · opposite · facing · surrounded by · enclosed by · bordered by · flanked by · on either side of · on the far side of · across the river from · in the top left-hand corner · along the coast · on the coastline · runs alongside · runs through · runs parallel to · cuts across · adjoins · borders · overlooks · stretches from [X] to [Y] · occupies the [eastern] half · lies between [X] and [Y] · within walking distance of · at the junction of

△ *in the north* = inside the area. *to the north of* = outside it. This is worth a mark. △ No compass rose drawn? **North is the top of the map.**

Change verbs — four families

Replace: was replaced by · gave way to · made way for · was converted into · was turned into · was transformed into · now occupies the site of · stands where [X] once stood

Add: was built · was constructed · was erected · appeared · was introduced · was added · sprang up · was developed · was laid out

Remove: was demolished · was pulled down · was knocked down · was cleared · was removed · disappeared · was lost to [housing] · no longer exists

Resize / move: was extended · was enlarged · was expanded · doubled in size · was widened · was reduced in size · was scaled back · was relocated to · was moved to the [north] of the site

Continuity: remained unchanged · was retained · was left intact · was untouched · survived the period · is still in place · continues to occupy

Ready sentences

- *The farmland to the north of the river gave way to a housing estate.*
- *A road bridge was built in place of the ferry crossing.*
- *The school was extended to twice its original size.*
- *The church at the centre of the village remained unchanged.*
- *The most far-reaching change was the loss of [farmland] on the [north] bank.*
- *[Ashcombe] has been transformed from a [farming] settlement into a [residential] one.*
- *The area has become considerably more built-up.*

Character-shift vocabulary for the overview

rural → residential · agricultural → industrial · industrial → leisure · undeveloped → urbanised · became more built-up · underwent extensive development · lost its [agricultural] character · was redeveloped for [housing]

Tense: second plan dated (2025) → past simple passive. Second plan undated (*today, now*) → present perfect passive. Second plan *proposed*

→ will be built

17. STATIC DIAGRAMS (an object or device — no time, no sequence)

△ **No trend verbs at all here.** *Rose, fell, increased, remained stable* are all factually wrong: the diagram shows a **difference**, not a change. △ **No sequencers either.** *Initially, subsequently, finally*

invent an order.

Parts — what it is made of

consists of · comprises (⚠ never *comprises of*) · is made up of · contains · is composed of · incorporates · features · is fitted with · is equipped with · is mounted on · is attached to · is connected to · is joined to · houses · is encased in · is enclosed within · is lined with · is coated in

Function — what a part does

serves to [X] · functions as [X] · acts as [X] · is responsible for [X] · allows [the water] to [pass] · enables [X] to [Y] · prevents [heat] from [escaping] · keeps [X] out · draws [water] up · channels [X] towards [Y] · supports · secures · seals · absorbs · traps · filters · regulates · transmits · converts [X] into [Y] · rotates · pivots · slides · swings · is designed to [X]

Position

at the base · at the upper end · at the top · directly beneath · immediately above · adjacent to · alongside · at either end · running the length of · on the underside · at right angles to · flush with · set into · recessed into · protruding from · vertically · horizontally · at the centre · around the perimeter · in the upper section

Comparison between two objects — the sentences that earn the band

- *Whereas the first design [uses a piston], the second [uses a rope loop].*
- *Unlike the first design, the second [has no moving parts below ground].*
- *In place of [the cylinder], the second design has [a narrow pipe].*
- *The equivalent component in the second design is [the guide block].*
- *A comparable function is performed by [the washers].*
- *Both designs share [a hand-operated drive].*
- *Neither design requires [an external power source].*
- *The chief difference lies in [how the water is lifted].*
- *The second design dispenses with the [sealed cylinder] found in the first.*
- *Where the first uses [X], the second uses [Y].*
- *The two perform the same task by fundamentally different means.*

Grouping — never object by object

Useful groups: *structure / power source / user interface · what it is made of / how it is held together · the part above ground / the part below · the parts that move / the parts that do not · input / output.*

⚠ You must **leave labels out**. Selection is the band-7 move here. ⚠ No commentary: you may say design B has fewer moving parts; you may not say it is therefore more reliable.

18. TABLES with no time dimension

Compare **across categories**, not over time. Present simple. No trend verbs.

Selecting

- *The most striking figures are for [X] and [Y].*
- *[X] records the highest figure in every column.*
- *[X] is the only category to exceed [90] in all three countries.*
- *The remaining categories cluster between [40] and [60].*
- *Mid-range figures show little variation and are not discussed here.*

Comparing across a row and down a column

- *Across all three countries, [nursing] graduates fare best.*
- *In every country, [fine art] comes bottom.*
- *[Canada] leads on all subjects except [nursing].*
- *The spread within [Portugal] is wider than in the other two countries.*
- *The gap between the best and worst categories is between [45] and [50] points.*
- *[X] varies little between countries, whereas [Y] varies considerably.*
- *The pattern is consistent across all three columns.*
- *The one exception to this pattern is [X].*

Naming the organising insight (a table overview must say something no cell says)

- *Overall, [the subject studied] matters far more than [the country of study].*
- *Overall, the differences between categories are far larger than the differences between countries.*
- *Overall, the figures divide into two clearly separated groups.*

⚠️ ❌ *Country A increased to 210* on an undated table → ✅ *Country A stands at 210.*

19. Cohesion without repeating nouns

Reference — point back with a short phrase

this figure · this trend · this pattern · this shift · this reversal · this change · these categories · these three countries · such growth · the former · the latter · both · the other two · the remaining two · the rest · the others · that of · those of · the same

Substitution and ellipsis

- *[A] rose sharply; [B] did so more gradually. (did so = rose)*
- *[A] was higher than that of [B]. (that = the figure)*
- *The figures for [A] exceeded those for [B]. (those = the figures)*

- *The number of children travelling by car rose, while the number walking fell.* (ellipsis — *of children* left out)
- *[A] rose, and so did [B].*
- *[A] fell; [B] did not.*

Ready cohesion sentences

- *This shift was the most striking feature of the period.*
- *The former rose steadily; the latter fell by a comparable margin.*
- *The remaining two categories followed the same downward path.*
- *Both moved in the same direction, though at very different speeds.*
- *The same was true of [B].*
- *In doing so, it overtook [B] for the first time.*

⚠ **Every substitute must have exactly one possible antecedent.** If *those* could point at two things, use ellipsis or repeat the noun. ⚠ *the former / the latter* work only with **exactly two** items, in that order. ⚠ *that of* is singular, *those of* is plural: ✗ *the figures for A exceeded that of B.*

20. Words to stop using, and what to use instead

Band-6 default	Band-7 replacement
a lot of · lots of	a substantial proportion of · a large share of
big / small (of a figure)	substantial / marginal · considerable / slight
went up / went down	rose / fell · climbed / declined
got bigger	grew · expanded · widened
a big rise	a substantial rise · a marked increase
very high	considerably higher · well above the rest
people	respondents · consumers · residents · households · participants
things	factors · categories · items · components
good / bad (of a figure)	favourable / unfavourable · strong / weak
the same time	the same period · concurrently
in the last	over the final [decade]
a small amount	a small quantity · a modest figure
more and more	increasingly · a growing number of
firstly / secondly / thirdly stacked	<i>(delete two of the three)</i>
moreover / furthermore at every sentence head	<i>(replace with reference — see §19)</i>
talk about	show · indicate · record
we can see that	the chart shows that <i>(or delete)</i>
in the other hand	on the other hand
in a first time	initially
it is to be noted that	notably
nowadays	at present · currently
percentage of people	the proportion of respondents

⚠ **The warning that matters more than the table.** A wrong upgrade scores **lower** than the plain word. *Sales rose sharply* beats *sales skyrocketed* used for a 5% rise. *Plummeted* for a 3% fall costs you twice — once on vocabulary, once on accuracy. Band-7 vocabulary is judged on **collocation and precision**, not rarity. If you are not certain the pairing is normal English, write the plain word.

Five that never survive the upgrade – use the plain form: ✗ *significant* → ✓ significant
✗ *augmented* → ✓ rose · increased
✗ *diminution* → ✓ decline · drop
✗ *the evolution of the trend* → ✓ the change · the trend
✗ *an important increase* → ✓ a substantial increase

The 60-second pre-flight

1. Time axis? If no → §10 only, no §3–§8.
2. Tense chosen (§14)?
3. Two groups named before typing?
4. Overview has no figures?
5. Both grammar shapes used (§9)?
6. Two reference items used (§19)?
7. Articles: bare general noun → no *the*; *the number/proportion/majority of*
.....
→ the
.
8. Every noun ending in -s: is it countable? (*information · research · advice · equipment · evidence · feedback · transport · traffic · expenditure* take no -s.)
9. 170–190 of my own words?

TASK 2 — the language bank

Use this while you write. Every line is a thing you can type as it stands. Square brackets [] are your slots. ⚠ = risky, read the warning. ✗ → ✓ = an error your French or Arabic will produce if you are not watching.

The 18 moves and the 12 starters live in 03-writing.md . This is the detail behind them.

1. The five question types, and what each demands

The instruction line you will actually see	What the essay must contain	The trap
"To what extent do you agree or disagree?" · "Do you agree or disagree?" · "What is your opinion?"	One clear position, held from the intro to the conclusion. Two developed reasons for it. One concession.	<i>To what extent</i> invites "I partly agree" — then you write one paragraph each way and never adjudicate. Partial is fine, but state it as a rule : "This holds for X but not for Y."
"Discuss both these views and give your own opinion."	Three things: view A developed, view B developed, your own view .	Reporting like a journalist — "Some say X, others say Y" — and your opinion arrives as a seven-word clause at the end. Put it in the intro's last sentence.
"What are the causes and what measures could be taken?" · "Why is this happening and what can be done?"	Named causes, then remedies that attack those exact causes , keyed back by name.	Mismatched halves: causes are poverty and weak enforcement, solutions are "raise awareness". Nothing joins. Costs you Task Response <i>and</i> Coherence.
"What are the advantages and disadvantages?"	Both sides described. A verdict is optional but safe.	Treating it as the <i>outweigh</i> version and forgetting to describe; or vice versa.
"Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?"	Both sides plus an explicit judgement of weight, with a named criterion .	Listing three of each, then "in conclusion there are both advantages and disadvantages". That is a missing demand — the band-5 cap.
"Why is this happening? Is it a positive or negative development?" (two-part / direct)	Two different answers to two different questions. Body 2 must evaluate , not add more causes.	Answering question 1 twice. Causes are easy, evaluation is hard, so body 2 quietly becomes another cause paragraph.

The 30-second triage. Find the last sentence with a question mark or an imperative. Count the separate demands in it. That number is how many things must be *visibly* on your page. Hybrid prompts exist — obey the demand count, never the family name.

2. Paraphrasing the prompt

Change the **nouns** and the **verb**. Keep the proposition identical. Do not change everything — a paraphrase that shifts the meaning puts you off-topic, which is worse than copying.

Prompt word	Swap it for
<i>Some people believe / think</i>	It is widely held that... · A common view is that... · One school of thought maintains that... · There is a widespread belief that...
<i>Some people argue / claim</i>	It is often argued that... · Some commentators contend that... · A frequent claim is that...
<i>Many people</i>	A large number of people · A significant proportion of the public · Many observers
<i>Some / others</i>	One group holds that... , while another maintains... · Opinion divides between those who... and those who...
<i>should</i>	ought to · would be better placed to · there is a case for [+ -ing] · it would be preferable for X to...
<i>nowadays / these days / in modern society</i>	in recent decades · over the past twenty years · increasingly · at present
<i>problem / issue / concern</i>	difficulty · challenge · a growing concern · a phenomenon (neutral) · a trend (neutral)
<i>a lot of / more and more</i>	a rising number of · a growing proportion of · an increasing share of
<i>the government</i>	policymakers · the authorities · the state · public bodies
<i>children / young people</i>	the young · adolescents · school-age children · the younger generation

Eight full patterns you can type over any prompt:

1. *It is widely held that [proposition]. [This essay will argue that / In my view] [your position].*
2. *Opinion is divided over whether [proposition]. [Position].*
3. *[Trend] has become increasingly common over the past two decades, and there is disagreement about whether [question].*
4. *A frequent claim is that [X]; others counter that [Y].*

5. *Whether [X] should [verb] is now a live question in many countries.*
6. *The rapid spread of [X] has prompted debate about [question].*
7. *Some argue for [noun phrase], on the grounds that [reason]. I find this [convincing / only partly convincing].*
8. *There is a strong case for [X], though it is weaker than its supporters suggest.*

⚠ Never lift a whole clause. Copied rubric earns nothing, is discounted from your word count, and is used as evidence that you cannot paraphrase. ⚠ Do not open with "In this contemporary era of rapid globalisation...". That is memorised language and it is listed as a marker of a low band.

3. Stating your position — at three strengths

Put it in **the last sentence of the introduction**, in one unambiguous sentence.

STRONG agreement

I agree entirely with this view, for two reasons. In my view this is not only true but urgent. There is little doubt that [X], and the case rests on [reason 1] and [reason 2]. I would go further than the statement suggests: [stronger version]. The argument for [X] seems to me decisive.

PARTIAL / qualified — use these most; they are safer and they score better

This holds for [vocational subjects], but not for [the humanities]. I agree with the principle, though not with the way it is usually applied. The claim is right about [causes] and wrong about [remedies]. [X] is justified, but only where [condition] is already in place. I accept the diagnosis but not the prescription. This is largely true of [group A]; for [group B] the opposite applies.

⚠ A qualified position must still be a **rule**, not a shrug. ✗ *There are arguments on both sides.* → ✓ *This is true where the alternative already exists, and false where it does not.*

DISAGREEMENT

I disagree with this view, although the concern behind it is legitimate. This argument mistakes [a symptom] for [a cause]. I find this unpersuasive, chiefly because [reason]. The evidence points the other way: [counter-claim]. The proposal would not achieve what its supporters want, and might make matters worse.

4. Topic sentences that carry a stance

A topic sentence must state the idea **and** signal your view. "Another factor is..." is the band-6 signature.

The stronger reason for rejecting this claim is that [X]. The most compelling argument in favour is [X], and it rests on [mechanism]. What makes this view difficult to sustain is [X]. The first of these causes is the easier to attack, because [reason]. The objection is serious, but it is an argument about [timing] rather than about [cars]. The clearest benefit, and the one that weighs most, is [X]. This is where the argument is at its weakest: [X]. A second and less obvious consequence is that [X].

✗ *In the other hand, another point is the pollution.* → ✓ *On the other hand, the environmental cost is harder to dismiss.*

5. Giving a reason

..., because [mechanism]. ..., since [mechanism]. (formal, good sentence-initially: Since costs fall on everyone, ...) ..., as [mechanism]. (⚠ as can also mean when — avoid it if the sentence could be misread) This is largely owing to [noun phrase]. This is due to [noun phrase]. This is due to the fact that [clause]. This stems from [noun phrase]. The primary reason is that [clause]. The explanation lies in [noun phrase]. A large part of the answer is [noun phrase]. [X] is the root of the difficulty.

⚠ **due to vs because of.** *Due to* attaches to a **noun** (usually after *is/was*): *The delay was due to congestion.* *Because of* attaches to a **verb or a whole clause**: *He was late because of congestion.* If you cannot tell, write **because of** — it is right far more often. ⚠ *Due to the fact that* is heavy. One per essay maximum; usually *because* is better.

✗ *Because of the pollution is increasing, people are ill.* → ✓ *Because pollution is increasing, people are falling ill.* (*because of* + noun; *because* + clause)

6. Cause and effect — the full set

CAUSE → EFFECT (subject is the cause)

[Overcrowding] leads to [higher rents]. [Automation] results in [job displacement in routine sectors]. [Rapid urbanisation] gives rise to [pressure on services]. [The policy] brought about [a measurable fall in traffic]. [Screen time] contributes to [declining physical activity]. (partial cause – safe, hedged) [The closure] triggered [a wave of departures]. (sudden, sharp events only) [Poor transport] drives [car dependency]. [The reform] paved the way for [wider access].

EFFECT ← CAUSE (subject is the effect)

[The shortage] stems from [decades of under-investment]. [This resentment] arises from [a sense of unfairness]. [The gap] is attributable to [differences in early schooling]. [Rising obesity] is a consequence of [cheap processed food and sedentary work]. [The decline] can be traced back to [the closure of the local industry]. [This behaviour] is rooted in [insecurity rather than preference].

Nouns – use these to compress a whole clause into a phrase

a driver of [X] · the principal driver of [X] a root cause · the underlying cause a knock-on effect · a ripple effect the fallout from [X] a side effect · an unintended consequence a feedback loop (each departure makes the next more likely) a trade-off

✗ *Pollution gives bad effects to the environment.* → ✓ *Industrial emissions place sustained strain on air quality.*

✗ *This problem is caused from bad management.* → ✓ *This problem is caused by poor management.*

7. Developing an idea – the four moves

claim → because → so what → example. Roughly 100 words. This is the single biggest band 6 → 7 lever in the whole paper. Band 6 *states* ideas; band 7 *extends and supports* them.

Move	What it does	Type this
Claim	The idea, one sentence. Carries your stance.	<i>The stronger reason for [X] is that...</i>
Because	The mechanism. Why is it true?	<i>This is because... · The reason is that... · ..., since... · which means that...</i>
So what	The consequence. Who gains, who loses, what follows.	<i>The consequence is that... · As a result... · What follows is that... · The effect is felt most by...</i>
Example	One concrete instance. Your own knowledge.	<i>For instance... · Take [X]... · A [student] who [situation] will...</i>

⚠ You may **invent** your examples. Nobody verifies them. No specialist knowledge is required and the rubric invites examples from your own experience. ⚠ But **no invented statistics**. A

significant minority scores the same as 63.4% and cannot embarrass you.

Worked example 1 — Education

(claim) The strongest argument against narrowing university provision is that the labour market a degree is designed for does not yet exist. **(because)** Curricula built around today's vacancies age badly, because the occupations they train for are precisely the ones most exposed to automation and offshoring. **(so what)** The consequence is that the most narrowly trained graduates are the first to need retraining, while those taught to argue, weigh evidence and write can move sideways. **(example)** A translation graduate I know found her specific technical skill automated within a decade, but the analytical training underneath it transferred without difficulty.

Worked example 2 — Environment

(claim) Congestion charging is the most defensible of the available measures. **(because)** This is because it prices the cost a driver imposes on everyone else — the delay, the noise, the particulates — which no fuel tax reaches. **(so what)** What follows is that traffic falls without anyone being banned, and the revenue can be redirected into the alternative that makes the charge tolerable. **(example)** In cities where the charge was introduced only after the bus network had been extended, public resistance faded within a few years; where it came first, it did not.

Worked example 3 — Work

(claim) The clearest cost of home working, and the one employers underestimate, is the loss of informal training. **(because)** Junior staff learn largely by overhearing — a half-finished negotiation, a senior colleague repairing a mistake — and that channel does not survive scheduled video calls. **(so what)** The effect is cumulative rather than immediate: the damage shows up several years later, in a generation of employees who were never apprenticed. **(example)** A graduate joining a law firm remotely may complete her tasks competently for two years and still not know how a client is handled when something goes wrong.

8. Giving examples

For instance, [example]. For example, [example]. A case in point is [X]. Take [Tunisia], for example: [what it shows]. Consider [the case of a graduate who...]. This can be seen in [countries that deregulated early]. As can be seen in [X], [what it shows], particularly in countries where [condition holds] especially among [households with the least slack in their week] A [student] who [situation], for example, will [outcome]. [X] is a good illustration of this. One need only look at [X].

⚠ Write **for example**, never *e.g.* An examiner logged *e.g.* as a lapse in an 8.5 script. Same for *etc.*

→ and so on

⚠ Two concrete instances across the essay is enough. An example in every sentence is padding.

9. Adding and extending

Moreover, [X]. In addition, [X]. What is more, [X]. Furthermore, [X]. Beyond this, [X]. A further consideration is [X].

⚠ **Maximum two markers per paragraph — and never zero.** Overuse is a named fault at band 7 and band 6. Four sequencers in one paragraph got an official 7.5 script marked down.

Extend without a new marker. Do this instead:

- **Relative clause:** *Rents rise fastest in exactly those districts where new building is hardest.*
- **Participle clause:** *Cities absorb people faster than they can house them, pushing rents beyond local wages.*
- **Reference:** *That mismatch shows up first in rents. · These pressures do not ease on their own.*
- **Substitution:** *the former · the latter · one · so · doing so · the remaining group*
- **Colon:** *The cause is not mysterious: the jobs are clustered and the housing is not.*
- **Semicolon:** *One is reversible; the other is not.*

✗ *Moreover, the pollution is a problem, furthermore the government must act.* → ✓ *Pollution is only half the difficulty; the response to it is the other half.*

10. Contrast and concession — the band-7 move

CONTRAST

However, [X]. By contrast, [X]. Conversely, [X]. On the other hand, [X]. [X], whereas [Y]. [X], while [Y]. Yet [X]. In reality, [X].

✗ *In the other hand* → ✓ **On the other hand.** ⚠ Check this one every time.

⚠ *However* is not a conjunction. ✗ *He tried, however he failed.* → ✓ *He tried; however, he failed. / He tried. However, he failed.*

CONCESSION

Although [X], [Y]. Even though [X], [Y]. While it is true that [X], [Y]. Admittedly, [X]. But [Y]. Granted, [X] – even so, [Y]. Despite [noun phrase], [Y]. Despite the fact that [clause], [Y]. It would be wrong to deny that [X]. There is real force in this objection.

✗ *Although many people believe this, but it is wrong.* → ✓ *Although many people believe this, it is wrong.* (English allows one, not both)

✗ *Despite of the cost* → ✓ *Despite the cost / In spite of the cost*

✗ *Despite the cost is high* → ✓ *Despite the high cost* (*despite* + noun, not clause)

CONCEDE-THEN-COUNTER – five full patterns. This is what makes an argument look mature.

1. *While [the objection] is undeniably true, it is an argument about [timing] rather than about [the measure itself].*
2. *There is real force in this objection; it applies, however, only where [condition], and that condition is becoming rarer.*
3. *Admittedly, [concession]. That cost is real, but it is [temporary / narrow / recoverable], whereas [the benefit] is [permanent / shared].*
4. *Supporters of this view are right that [X]. Where the argument fails is in assuming that [unstated assumption].*
5. *[Concession] is often raised, and it deserves an answer rather than a dismissal: [answer].*

⚠ Concede **once**, then counter. A concession without a counter is a lost paragraph.

11. Hedging — free marks

An examiner named softeners of exactly this kind as evidence of higher-level vocabulary in a 7.5 script. It raises Lexical Resource **and** kills band 7's named weakness (over-generalising) in the same word.

tend to · tends to be · are likely to · may well · can (not will) in most cases · in many countries · broadly speaking · by and large often · typically · generally · for the most part arguably · it could be argued that · there is a case for saying that this suggests · this points to · appears to be · seems to a significant minority · a large proportion · few, if any

Before → after

✗ Overgeneralised	✓ Hedged
<i>Everyone uses social media all day.</i>	<i>Most adults now spend a substantial part of the day online.</i>
<i>Poor students always fail at university.</i>	<i>Students from low-income households tend to be at a disadvantage, and in many cases drop out earlier.</i>
<i>Technology destroys jobs.</i>	<i>Automation is likely to displace routine work faster than it replaces it.</i>
<i>Living in a city makes people unhappy.</i>	<i>City life appears to carry costs to wellbeing that are easy to underestimate, particularly for those on low incomes.</i>

⚠ Do not hedge your **position**. Hedge the generalisations inside it. A position hedged into invisibility is a band-6 position.

12. Emphasising

Crucially, [X]. Above all, [X]. Most importantly, [X]. particularly in [context] · especially where [condition] What matters most is [X]. It is precisely this that [makes the measure worth taking]. The decisive point is that [X]. This is the heart of the matter. It is worth stressing that [X]. Indeed, [stronger restatement].

⚠ Do **not** use *very, really, absolutely, totally*, or capital letters, or an exclamation mark. Emphasis in academic English is lexical, not loud.

13. Weighing and judging (for "outweigh" questions)

A verdict must **name the criterion** it rests on. "Overall I think the advantages are more important" is asserted, not weighed.

On balance, the advantages outweigh the drawbacks. The benefits outweigh the costs, though not by as wide a margin as is often claimed. The drawbacks are real, but they are outweighed by [X]. While [X] carries a genuine cost, [Y] is the greater consideration. The two are not comparable in weight: one is [reversible], the other is not. The first cost is temporary and local; the second is permanent and shared. The gains are structural and compounding, while the losses are a training problem firms can deliberately solve. Taking both sides together, the case for [X] is the stronger. The balance tips towards [X], chiefly because [criterion].

Criteria you can name in one clause — use one of these and a band-6 verdict becomes a band-7 one:

permanent vs temporary · shared vs narrow · reversible vs irreversible · affects more people · falls on those least able to bear it · compounding over time · solvable by policy vs not

14. Proposing solutions

Governments should [verb], because [why it attacks the cause]. One measure would be to [verb]. A more effective approach would be to [verb]. This could be addressed by [+ -ing]. This is best tackled at the level of [X] rather than [Y]. Legislation requiring [employers to X] would [effect]. Subsidising [X] would remove the incentive that produces [Y]. The most practical step is [X], and it is also the cheapest. Schools could be required to [verb], which would [effect]. A guaranteed [service floor] below which closure is not permitted would break the loop. Redirecting [revenue from X] into [Y] would make the measure politically survivable.

⚠ **Every solution must answer a cause you named**, and must say so:

The first of these causes is the easier to attack, because [reason]. Neither of these remedies touches the second cause, which is why [X] is also needed.

⚠ Name **the actor, the instrument and the mechanism** — who does what, and why it changes the cause. ✗ *The government should raise awareness and people must be more responsible.* → ✓ *Municipal authorities could make separated collection the default, since households recycle at far higher rates when doing so requires no extra effort.*

15. Conclusions

In conclusion, [verdict], because [the criterion the verdict rests on]. To sum up, the case for [X] rests less on [Y] than on [Z]. On balance, then, [verdict] – provided that [condition]. The argument therefore comes down to [criterion], and on that test [X] wins. [X] is worth doing, but only alongside [Y]; on its own it will disappoint. The problem is tractable, but only if the remedies are aimed at the causes named above rather than at the symptoms. In short, [position restated in new words], and the reason is [criterion]. If [the condition] holds, [verdict]; if it does not, the objection stands.

⚠ **No new ideas.** A conclusion that introduces an argument is an undeveloped paragraph. ⚠ **Restate in different words.** A conclusion that repeats the introduction is "repetitive", which is a named band-6 fault. ⚠ Give a **reason**, not a summary. Band 6 conclusions say *there are advantages and disadvantages*; band 7 conclusions say *why one side weighed more*.

16. Topic vocabulary — the eight recurring themes

Collocations, not single words. Band 7 asks for awareness of **collocation** — the partnerships English habitually makes. Ten precise phrases beat twenty synonyms for *important*.

Education

widen access to higher education · vocational training · the attainment gap · tuition fees · rote learning · critical thinking skills · the school curriculum · drop-out rates · streaming by ability · lifelong learning · contact hours · teacher retention · transferable skills · state-funded places

Technology

digital literacy · the digital divide · automation of routine tasks · data privacy · screen time · online platforms · algorithmic recommendation · technological disruption · displace human labour · roll out broadband · remote access · a reliance on devices · emerging technologies

Environment

carbon emissions · renewable energy · fossil fuels · air quality · single-use plastics · waste management · the depletion of natural resources · biodiversity loss · environmental degradation · a carbon footprint · sustainable development · green infrastructure · offset emissions · climate targets

Health

preventive care · a sedentary lifestyle · processed food · public health campaigns · life expectancy · mental wellbeing · the healthcare system · chronic illness · access to treatment · health inequalities · an ageing population · a balanced diet · under-resourced hospitals

Work

job security · work–life balance · the labour market · unpaid overtime · remote working · a skills shortage · career progression · workplace flexibility · the gig economy · staff turnover · in-work training · a living wage · employment prospects · burnout

Crime

crime rates · deterrent effect · rehabilitation of offenders · custodial sentences · reoffending rates · petty crime · organised crime · community policing · the root causes of crime · restorative justice · surveillance cameras · overcrowded prisons · a criminal record

Globalisation

cross-border trade · multinational corporations · cultural homogenisation · outsourcing production · economic interdependence · cheap imports · the erosion of local traditions · a brain drain · global supply chains · labour mobility · protectionist measures · foreign direct investment · cultural exchange

Media

media coverage · sensationalist reporting · press freedom · misinformation · editorial independence · shape public opinion · a 24-hour news cycle · citizen journalism · state-controlled media · media literacy · biased reporting · the public interest · echo chambers

⚠ Do not force a rare word into a phrase it does not belong in. *Ameliorate* is a real word; *ameliorate a predicament* is not English. A wrong upgrade scores **lower** than the plain word. ✗ *the informations in the medias* → ✓ *the information in the media*

17. Idea banks for the same eight themes

Four **for**, four **against**, one line each, ready for the four-move treatment. This is what stops you staring at a blank screen.

Education

FOR (more state involvement / broad education) - An educated population raises productivity for everyone, not just the graduate. - Broad training survives occupational change; narrow training does not. - Free or subsidised access breaks the link between a family's income and a child's ceiling. - Universities produce research that no private firm has an incentive to fund.

AGAINST - Public funding is finite, and every subsidised place is a place not funded elsewhere. - Degrees increasingly signal ability rather than teach skills employers actually need. - Expanding numbers has devalued the qualification and lengthened the queue. - Vocational routes are cheaper, faster and closer to real vacancies.

Technology

FOR - Automation removes dangerous and repetitive work that nobody wants to do. - Access to information no longer depends on living near a library or a good school. - Remote tools widen the hiring pool beyond the commuting distance of a capital city. - Diagnostic and monitoring technology catches illness earlier and cheaply.

AGAINST - The gains accrue to those who already have connectivity, widening existing gaps. - Routine jobs disappear faster than displaced workers can be retrained. - Constant availability erodes the boundary between working and living. - Recommendation systems narrow what people see rather than broadening it.

Environment

FOR (regulation / individual restraint) - Environmental damage is an externality: the polluter does not pay the cost. - Some damage is irreversible, so caution is worth more than it looks. - Early action is cheaper than adaptation later. - Green industries create employment as older sectors contract.

AGAINST / the objection - Restrictions fall hardest on low-income households, who spend the largest share on energy. - Unilateral limits simply relocate production to countries with weaker rules. - Individual behaviour is trivial beside industrial and state emissions. - Growth is what funds the technology that eventually solves the problem.

Health

FOR (state responsibility / prevention) - Prevention costs a fraction of treatment and reaches people earlier. - Ill health is not evenly distributed; it tracks income and postcode. - A healthy workforce is an economic asset, not merely a moral good. - Individuals cannot regulate the food industry, but governments can.

AGAINST - Personal responsibility matters; no policy can make anyone exercise. - Taxes on food and drink are regressive and hit the poorest hardest. - Public systems ration by waiting time, which has its own human cost. - Ageing populations make universal free provision arithmetically harder every year.

Work

FOR (flexibility / worker protection) - Removing the commute returns hours to precisely the households with least slack. - Flexible hours keep parents and carers in the labour market instead of out of it. - Secure contracts make workers willing to train and to speak up. - Overwork lowers output per hour; rested employees produce more.

AGAINST - Informal mentoring does not survive scheduled calls; juniors lose most. - Flexibility for the employer often means insecurity for the employee. - Weak dismissal rules make firms readier to hire in the first place. - Home working shifts costs — heating, space, equipment — onto the worker.

Crime

FOR (rehabilitation / social causes) - Certainty of being caught deters far more than severity of punishment. - Prison without training produces reoffenders at public expense. - Most acquisitive crime tracks unemployment and inequality, not leniency. - Early intervention with young offenders is the cheapest point to break the cycle.

AGAINST (deterrence / punishment) - Sentences express public condemnation, and that has value beyond deterrence. - Incapacitation works: an offender in custody commits no street crime. - Victims are entitled to proportionate punishment, not only offender welfare. - Lenient sentencing undermines confidence in the system and encourages private retaliation.

Globalisation

FOR - Trade lowers prices, and the largest benefit goes to those with the least income. - Access to foreign markets lets small economies specialise instead of doing everything badly. - Movement of workers transfers skills in both directions. - Cultural exchange has enriched food, music and language everywhere it has happened.

AGAINST - Gains are national averages; the losses are concentrated in particular towns. - Local industries cannot compete with subsidised imports and do not recover. - Skilled emigration drains exactly the people a developing economy needs most. - Global brands displace local practice faster than any deliberate policy could.

Media

FOR (free press / broad access) - Scrutiny of power is impossible without an independent press. - More sources make it harder for any single account to go unchallenged. - Citizen reporting covers places professional journalists never reach. - Public broadcasting sets a quality floor that commercial pressure would remove.

AGAINST - Attention is what sells, so alarming stories crowd out important ones. - Coverage shapes what people fear far more accurately than it shapes what they know. - Anonymity online lowers the cost of spreading falsehood to almost nothing. - Concentrated ownership means "many outlets" can still mean one voice.

18. Words to stop using, and what to replace them with

✗ Band-6 default	✓ Replace with
<i>nowadays / in today's world</i>	in recent decades · over the past twenty years · increasingly (or delete it)
<i>big problem</i>	a serious difficulty · a persistent challenge · a growing concern
<i>good / bad</i>	beneficial · damaging · valuable · counterproductive
<i>very important</i>	crucial · decisive · central to · what matters most is
<i>a lot of / lots of</i>	a large number of · a substantial proportion of · considerable
<i>thing / stuff</i>	factor · feature · aspect · consideration · element
<i>people (repeated)</i>	households · workers · residents · commuters · parents · the public
<i>society (repeated)</i>	communities · the wider population · public life
<i>get</i>	obtain · acquire · receive · reach
<i>make better</i>	improve · strengthen · enhance
<i>make worse</i>	aggravate · worsen · compound
<i>more and more</i>	a rising number of · an increasing share of
<i>I think / in my opinion I think</i>	in my view · I would argue that (pick one, never both)
<i>we can say that / it is a fact that</i>	(delete — say the thing)
<i>firstly, secondly, thirdly at every head</i>	(keep one; carry the rest with reference and substitution)
<i>In conclusion I want to say that</i>	In conclusion, [verdict], because...
<i>the youth are</i>	young people are
<i>this essay will talk about</i>	this essay argues that [position]
<i>give bad effects to</i>	place strain on · damage · undermine
<i>the environment problem</i>	environmental damage · the environmental cost
<i>develop the country</i>	raise living standards · build infrastructure · grow the economy

⚠ **A wrong upgrade scores lower than the plain word.** Band 6 is *defined* partly by the risk-taker who reaches for wider vocabulary at the cost of accuracy. If you are not certain of the collocation, use the plain word.

False friends that will appear in your Task 2 essays ✗ *significant* → ✓ **significant**

✗ *alimentation* → ✓ **diet / nutrition**

✗ *formation* → ✓ **training / education**

✗ *evolution* (meaning a trend) → ✓ **change / development**

- ✗ *inconvenient* (as a noun) → ✓ **drawback / disadvantage**
- ✗ *society* (meaning a firm) → ✓ **company**
- ✗ *actually* (meaning currently) → ✓ **at present / currently**
- ✗ *eventually* (meaning possibly) → ✓ **possibly / if necessary**
- ✗ *assist to a lecture* → ✓ **attend a lecture**
- ✗ *permit to do* → ✓ **allow people to do / permit people to do**
- ✗ *sensible* (meaning sensitive) → ✓ **sensitive**
- ✗ *deception* (meaning disappointment) → ✓ **disappointment**
- ✗ *support* (meaning tolerate) → ✓ **tolerate / put up with**
- ✗ *demand* (meaning ask) → ✓ **ask**
- ✗ *achieve* (meaning finish) → ✓ **complete / finish**

Prepositions the argument itself will trip you on ✗ *depend of* → ✓ **depend on** · ✗ *discuss about* → ✓ **discuss** Ø ·

✗ *participate to* → ✓ **participate in** · ✗ *responsible of* → ✓ **responsible**

for · ✗ *access to the internet* (as a verb) → ✓ **access** Ø the internet · ✗ *prevent somebody to do* → ✓ **prevent somebody from doing** ·

✗ *consist in* → ✓ **consist of** · ✗ *suffer of* → ✓ **suffer from** ·

✗ *interested by* → ✓ **interested in** · ✗ *in the other hand* → ✓ **on the other hand**

Articles — the scan that decides 6 from 7 ✗ *the society · the technology · the education · the nature · the pollution* ·

the crime · the poverty → ✓ **drop the article** when the noun is general. ✓ **Keep** the article in: *the government · the environment · the media · the economy · the internet · the public · the police · the countryside · the climate*. ✓ **Keep** it whenever something after the noun says *which one*: *the education system of Tunisia · the crime rate · the poverty that this policy creates*.

Uncountables — check every noun ending in -s ✗ *informations · researches · advices · knowledges · equipments · furnitures* ·

softwares · evidences · feedbacks · peoples (unless you mean ethnic groups) · *gossips* → ✓ **information · research · advice · knowledge · equipment · furniture · software · evidence · feedback · people · gossip**. Say *a piece of research, some advice, two pieces of evidence*.

19. Register — what not to write

✗ Do not write	✓ Write
<i>don't · can't · won't · it's · doesn't</i>	do not · cannot · will not · it is · does not
<i>You should exercise more.</i>	People should exercise more. · Individuals ought to...
<i>kids · guys · a huge amount of · a bit</i>	children · people · a substantial number of · slightly
<i>e.g.</i>	for example
<i>etc.</i>	and so on
<i>&</i>	and
<i>Isn't it obvious that pollution is bad? Who benefits? Why do we allow this?</i>	(rhetorical question chains: delete. A question is not a position.)
<i>This is terrible!</i>	This is difficult to defend. (no exclamation marks — not one)
<i>Bullet points · sub-headings · numbered lists</i>	Continuous prose. Note form is penalisable anywhere in the response.
<i>ALL CAPS · bold for emphasis</i>	Lexical emphasis: <i>crucially · above all · what matters most</i>
<i>Let's look at... · Now I will discuss...</i>	(delete — just write the paragraph)
<i>In my opinion I think that...</i>	In my view... (pick one)
<i>Stats I invented: "73% of students..."</i>	A significant minority of students...

⚠ One contraction will not cap you — an official 7.5 script used *don't* three times. But they buy nothing and cost a little, so keep avoiding them. **Do not spend exam minutes hunting contractions while a question part sits unanswered.**

The 60-second pre-submit scan

1. Position stated in the intro's **last sentence**?
2. One paragraph per demand — count them against the instruction line.
3. Every topic sentence carries a **stance**, not just a topic?
4. Four moves in each body paragraph — claim, because, so what, example?
5. **Articles**: every *the* before a bare abstract noun. And every abstract noun on the counter-list that has lost one.

6. **Plurals:** information · research · advice · knowledge · evidence · equipment · people — any of them wearing an -s?
7. **Commas:** any comma with a complete sentence on both sides.
8. **-s:** every present-simple verb with a singular subject.
9. Discourse markers: no paragraph with more than two, none with zero.
10. *On the other hand*, not *in the other hand*.

⚠ In these last three minutes you may **delete and repair**. **Never add**. A sentence written at minute 39 is unproofread by definition.

GRAMMAR ON DEMAND

How to use this

You do not read this. You look things up in it: find the structure you need, copy the pattern, swap in your own content. Before you write it, read the ✗ → ✓ lines underneath — those are the errors *you* make in that structure, not generic ones. One rule governs the whole file: a complex sentence you cannot check is worth less than a simple sentence you can. Accuracy parity is the target, not more complexity.

The order to learn them

Articles, agreement and punctuation (§9, §10, §11) are not on this list. They are not structures you choose — they run underneath every sentence you write, and they are always on. Everything below is optional, and ranked by what it pays after the risk is subtracted.

Structure	What it costs you to get wrong	Learn it when
§2 Relative clauses	Almost nothing — this is the one complex structure you get right at the rate band 7 needs	Now. Before anything else here.
§1 Comparatives	Visible in one glance, and Task 1 is built out of them	Now. Every Task 1 needs them.
§5 Concession clauses	<i>Although...but</i> and <i>despite</i> + clause are your highest-frequency complex-sentence errors	Now. You already use these — you just use them wrong.
§4 The passive	Required in process tasks; the intransitive passive (<i>was happened</i>) is a real error, not a slip	Week 1, or the first time a process diagram appears.
§6 Participle clauses	A dangling participle makes the sentence say something absurd	After relative clauses are automatic — it is the same move, shortened.
§3 Second conditional	One pattern, and the <i>would-in-the-if</i> -clause error is the only way to fail it	After articles are under control. One pattern, drilled cold.
§7 Nominalisation	Buys register, but every single one creates a new article decision	Only once your article error rate is under 10%.
§8 Cleft sentences	Used twice, it reads as a memorised template	Last. One per essay, no more.
§3 Third conditional	Nothing to gain. Candidates at every band, up to the top, essentially never write one	Never. Rewrite it in the past simple instead.

1. COMPARATIVES AND SUPERLATIVES

The patterns

Adjective	Comparative	Superlative
Short (1 syllable, or 2 ending in -y)	higher, larger, easier, cheaper	the highest, the largest, the easiest
Long (2+ syllables)	more expensive, more significant, more reliable	the most expensive, the most significant
Irregular	better · worse · further · less · more	the best · the worst · the furthest · the least · the most

- **than**, never *that*: *higher than in 2010*.
- **the** + superlative, always — unless a possessive is already there: *the highest figure*, but *its highest level*.
- Equality: **as ... as**. *as high as · not as high as · the same as***.

Rates of car ownership were higher in urban areas than in rural ones throughout the period. Renewable sources accounted for the largest share of generation by 2020. Distance learning is more accessible but less effective for practical subjects.

Intensifying a comparison

Put the intensifier **in front of** the comparative:

far · significantly · considerably · substantially · markedly · slightly · marginally + comparative

Public transport use was considerably higher in the capital than in any other region. Female enrolment rose only marginally faster than male enrolment.

And for superlatives: **by far the** largest / the smallest / the most common.

Road transport remained by far the largest source of urban emissions.

⚠ *very* cannot intensify a comparative. *Very high* ✓, *very higher* ✗ — use *far*.

Multiples

- **twice as many** commuters **as** in 2005
- **three times higher than** the national average

- **half as much** electricity **as** the previous decade
- **a tenfold rise in** applications · **a fivefold increase in** demand
- **double the** number of · **ten per cent more than**

By 2018 the city was processing three times as much waste as it had a decade earlier, a twofold increase on the regional average.

Your errors

- ✗ more higher → ✓ higher
- ✗ more bigger → ✓ bigger
- ✗ more cheaper → ✓ cheaper
- ✗ the most highest → ✓ the highest
- ✗ the most largest → ✓ the largest
- ✗ bigger that the others → ✓ bigger **than** the others
- ✗ more good → ✓ better
- ✗ more bad → ✓ worse
- ✗ as high than → ✓ as high **as**
- ✗ the same than in 2010 → ✓ the same **as** in 2010
- ✗ very higher → ✓ far higher
- ✗ twice more than → ✓ twice as many **as**
- ✗ It is the more important factor → ✓ It is **the most** important factor
- ✗ highest figure of all → ✓ **the** highest figure of all

2. RELATIVE CLAUSES

Your best structure. You get relative clauses right at a rate no other complex structure in your profile comes close to, and band-7 writers use roughly twice as many of them as band-6 writers. When you need a complex sentence, reach here first.

Defining vs non-defining — the comma rule in one line

Say the sentence without the clause. If the reader would no longer know which thing you mean, use no commas. If they would still know, use commas both sides.

	Defining (no commas)	Non-defining (commas both sides)
Job	Tells the reader which one	Adds extra information about something already identified
<i>that</i> allowed?	Yes	No — use <i>which</i> or <i>who</i>
Pronoun droppable?	Yes, when it is the object	No

Students who live far from campus miss more classes. — only those students *Students, who live far from campus, miss more classes.* — **all** students live far from campus, which is almost never what you meant

That comma is not decoration. It changes the fact you are asserting.

The relativisers

Word	Refers to	Example
who	people	<i>workers who commute more than an hour</i>
which	things	<i>policies which target congestion</i>
that	people or things — defining only	<i>countries that invest early</i>
whose	possession (people <i>and</i> things)	<i>families whose income falls below the line</i>
where	places	<i>regions where rainfall is unreliable</i>

Dropping the pronoun

When the relativiser is the **object** of the clause, you can delete it. Free concision, no risk.

The measures (that) the council introduced in 2019 have barely affected congestion.

"which" referring to a whole clause

Use *which* — with a comma, always — to comment on everything you just said.

Tuition fees have risen faster than average incomes, which has deterred applicants from low-income families.

⚠ Comma compulsory, and never *that* for this job. ✗ *...incomes that has deterred...*

Reduced relatives — the repair that is also an upgrade

Delete the relativiser and the *be*-verb. Shorter, and it still counts as range.

Full	Reduced
<i>students who live in rural areas</i>	<i>students living in rural areas</i>
<i>the measures which were introduced in 2020</i>	<i>the measures introduced in 2020</i>
<i>households that rely on a single income</i>	<i>households relying on a single income</i>

-ing for active, **past participle** for passive. This is the single highest-value move in this file for you, because it kills your Arabic missing-relativiser error and produces a band-7 structure in the same stroke.

5 model sentences

1. *Countries that invest early in vocational training report lower youth unemployment.*
2. *Vocational training, which costs a fraction of a degree to deliver, reaches students whom academic routes never see.*
3. *Cities where cycling infrastructure is separated from traffic show the sharpest rise in bicycle use.*
4. *Families whose income falls below the poverty line spend a larger share of it on food.*
5. *Employees working from home two days a week report the highest job satisfaction.*

Your errors

- ✗ people which live abroad → ✓ people **who** live abroad
- ✗ the students which their parents work → ✓ the students **whose** parents work
- ✗ the reason why that people migrate → ✓ the reason **why** people migrate (never *why + that*)
- ✗ The reform which the ministry announced **it** in 2019 → ✓ ...the ministry announced in 2019
- ✗ The residents who the survey contacted **them** → ✓ The residents **whom** the survey contacted
- ✗ the district where the tramline was built **in it** → ✓ the district **where** the tramline was built
- ✗ There are many households live below the line → ✓ ...households **that live / living** below the line
- ✗ Vocational training which costs far less reaches more students → ✓ Vocational training, which costs far less, reaches more students
- ✗ The internet, **that** has changed research, ... → ✓ The internet, **which** has changed research, ...
- ✗ A child who spend three hours online → ✓ A child who **spends** three hours online
- ✗ policies who target congestion → ✓ policies **which/that** target congestion
- ⚠ Two relative clauses in one sentence is one more than you can check under the clock. One per sentence.

3. CONDITIONALS

FIRST — a real future condition

If + present simple, ... will + base verb.

If governments invest in rail, congestion will fall within a decade. Unless fares are subsidised, ridership will continue to decline.

Use it freely. It is low-risk and it does real work in Task 2 predictions.

SECOND — hypothetical, not real

If + past simple, ... would + base verb.

If governments invested in rail, congestion would fall within a decade. If public transport were free, more commuters would abandon their cars.

Were is the better academic choice; *was* is standard modern English and nobody can defensibly mark it wrong. Prefer *were*, do not fear *was*.

THIRD — skip it

Do not write one. Candidates at every band, including the top, essentially never produce a third conditional, so it buys you nothing and it is a three-part structure to get wrong under the clock. When you find yourself starting *If governments had..., they would have...*, rewrite it in the past simple with a consequence:

Governments failed to act in the 1990s, and emissions rose accordingly.

Master the second. Use the first freely. Skip the third and mixed entirely.

Your errors

- ✗ If governments **would invest**, congestion would fall → ✓ If governments **invested**, congestion would fall
- ✗ If the subsidy **will end** next year, prices will rise → ✓ If the subsidy **ends** next year, prices will rise
- ✗ If governments invested, congestion **will** fall → ✓ ...congestion **would** fall
- ✗ If cities banned cars, air quality **would improve** → ✓ ...**would improve**
- ✗ **Unless if** fares are cut → ✓ **Unless** fares are cut (*unless* already means *if not*)
- ✗ If it **would be** cheaper, more people would use it → ✓ If it **were** cheaper, ...

⚠ The rule behind all of these: **no modal inside the if-clause**. Ever.

4. THE PASSIVE

When it is required

- **Process diagrams** — the doer is a machine or nobody, and the stages are the point.
- **When the doer is unknown, obvious, or irrelevant.**
- **When you want the affected thing to be the topic** of the sentence.

Not everywhere. A passive in every sentence hides who is responsible, and Task Response wants a clear position.

The forms

Form	Pattern	Example
Present	is / are + past participle	<i>The harvested cane is washed and then crushed.</i>
Past	was / were + pp	<i>Tuition fees were frozen for three consecutive years.</i>
Present perfect	has / have been + pp	<i>The scheme has been extended twice since 2015.</i>
Modal	can / should / must be + pp	<i>Emissions can be reduced without new technology.</i>
Modal perfect	should have been + pp	<i>The policy should have been evaluated before it was extended.</i>
Continuous	is / are being + pp	<i>Three new lines are being built simultaneously.</i>

Add *by* only when the agent genuinely matters.

Your errors

- ✗ The scheme **is consist of** three stages → ✓ The scheme **consists of** three stages
- ✗ An accident **was happened** at the junction → ✓ An accident **happened** at the junction
- ✗ The number of visitors **was risen** sharply → ✓ The number of visitors **rose** sharply
- ✗ This **is occurred** mainly in coastal regions → ✓ This **occurs** mainly in coastal regions
- ✗ A new problem **was appeared** after 2016 → ✓ A new problem **appeared** after 2016
- ✗ The figure **was remained** stable → ✓ The figure **remained** stable
- ✗ It **is depend on** the region → ✓ It **depends on** the region

⚠ **Intransitive verbs have no passive at all.** *happen · occur · arise · appear · exist · rise · fall · emerge · remain · consist* take no object, so there is nothing to promote to subject. No object, no passive, ever.

5. CONCESSION CLAUSES

Three groups. They all mean "contrast" and they take three different things after them.

Word	Takes	Example
although · even though · though	a clause (subject + verb)	<i>Although fees have risen, applications continue to grow.</i>
while · whereas	a clause	<i>Whereas rural clinics are understaffed, urban hospitals turn patients away.</i>
despite · in spite of	a noun or an -ing form	<i>Despite the rise in fees, applications continue to grow.</i>
however · nevertheless · nonetheless	nothing — they are adverbs, not joiners	<i>Fees have risen. However, applications continue to grow.</i>

Three ways to fix a *despite* + clause, all correct:

Despite its unpopularity, the tax has cut consumption. (noun) *Despite being unpopular, the tax has cut consumption.* (-ing) *Despite the fact that the tax is unpopular, it has cut consumption.* (clumsy but correct — and correct beats elegant)

Your errors

- ✗ *despite of the cost* → ✓ **despite** the cost
- ✗ *in spite the cost* → ✓ **in spite of** the cost
- ✗ *Although the tax is unpopular, but it works* → ✓ *Although the tax is unpopular, it works*
- ✗ *Even though fees rose, however applications grew* → ✓ *Even though fees rose, applications grew*
- ✗ *Despite the tax is unpopular* → ✓ *Despite its unpopularity* / *Despite the fact that the tax is unpopular*
- ✗ *Despite of the fact that* → ✓ *Despite the fact that*
- ✗ *Fees have doubled, however applications rise* → ✓ *Fees have doubled. However, applications rise*
- ✗ *Although of the cost* → ✓ **Although** the cost **is high**

⚠ English allows exactly **one** joining word between two clauses. Both Arabic and French let you echo the contrast in the second clause. English does not.

6. PARTICIPLE CLAUSES

The patterns

Pattern	Example
-ing , active	<i>Lacking reliable transport, rural students miss classes.</i>
Having + past participle	<i>Having introduced a congestion charge, the city saw traffic fall by a fifth.</i>
Faced with X	<i>Faced with rising rents, young workers are delaying home ownership.</i>
Being unable to X	<i>Being unable to afford childcare, many mothers leave the workforce.</i>
Trailing -ing (comments on the main clause)	<i>Enrolment doubled between 2010 and 2020, rising fastest in the final three years.</i>

The trailing *-ing* clause is worth more to you than the other four combined, because it is tailor-made for Task 1:

Solar generation reached 40 terawatt-hours, accounting for roughly a quarter of supply.

⚠ Dangerous — one failure mode, and it is severe

The subject immediately after the comma must be the thing doing the participle. Mismatch it and the sentence says something absurd.

- ✗ *Having banned diesel cars from the centre, air quality improved within a year.* — the air quality banned the cars
- ✓ *Having banned diesel cars from the centre, the city saw air quality improve within a year.*
- ✓ *After the city banned diesel cars from the centre, air quality improved within a year.*

One-second check: put your finger on the word right after the comma. Is that the thing doing the participle? If not, rewrite with *Because / After / Since*.

Your errors

- ✗ Lacking formal qualifications, **employers** rarely shortlist these candidates → ✓ Lacking formal qualifications, **these candidates** are rarely shortlisted
- ✗ Being unable to afford housing, **the government** must intervene → ✓ Being unable to afford housing, **young workers** need government help
- ✗ Having completed the training, **a certificate** is issued → ✓ Having completed the training, **participants** receive a certificate

7. NOMINALISATION

Take the action out of the verb, pack it into a noun, rebuild the sentence around the noun. This is what makes English academic prose sound academic.

Verb	Noun form to reach for
decide	the decision to
introduce	the introduction of
grow	growth in
rely	reliance on
regulate	the regulation of / <i>strict regulation</i>
expand	the expansion of
fail	the failure to
lose	the loss of

Before and after

Before: *Governments regulate emissions strictly, and this has cut air pollution.* **After:** *Strict regulation of emissions has cut air pollution.*

You have gained register, you have gained a noun you can now refer back to (*Such regulation...*, *This decline...*, which pays you under Coherence and Cohesion), and you have removed a clause — and with it a chance to make an agreement error.

Your errors

- ✗ the decision **of building** a new line → ✓ the decision **to build** a new line
- ✗ the reliance **of** rural clinics **of** central funding → ✓ the reliance **of** rural clinics **on** central funding
- ✗ a growth **of** the population → ✓ growth **in** the population
- ✗ The introduction **of the** charge **have** reduced traffic → ✓ The introduction of the charge **has** reduced traffic

⚠ **The tax on this one is specific to you.** Every nominalisation creates a **new article decision** — *governments regulate* has no article problem, *the strict regulation of emissions introduced in 2019* has one. Articles are your most expensive error. **Fix articles first, then nominalise.** Run §9 on every noun you create.

8. CLEFT SENTENCES

Split one ordinary sentence in two so that the part you most want noticed sits under a lamp.

Pattern	Example
<i>It is/was X that/who ...</i>	<i>It is the shortage of qualified teachers, rather than of buildings, that limits access to education in rural areas.</i>
<i>What ... is/was X</i>	<i>What these figures do not show is how the cost is distributed across income groups.</i>
<i>What matters most is ...</i>	<i>What matters most is not how much is spent but where it is spent.</i>

Use it once — to state a thesis, or to land the point you most want taken from a body paragraph.

Your errors

- ✗ What matters **are** the outcomes → ✓ What matters **is** the outcome (*What matters* is singular)
- ✗ It is the teachers who **limits** access → ✓ It is the teachers who **limit** access
- ✗ It is because of the cost **which** applications fell → ✓ It is because of the cost **that** applications fell

⚠ **One per essay, no more.** Three clefts stops reading as control and starts reading as a memorised template — which is a scored penalty, not a style opinion.

9. ARTICLES — the one that decides your band

The full **drop-list** and **keep-list** are on the error card — see `playbook/04-speaking-language.md` §Articles and §The nine uncountables, and `book/appendix-C-error-card.md`.

Do not learn them twice. What belongs here is the **procedure**, which you run on the **head noun** — the one noun the phrase is actually about, once you strip everything piled in front of and behind it.

STEP 1 – Is the head noun COUNTABLE?

NO (information, advice, research, equipment, evidence, knowledge, feedback, software, furniture, traffic, education, pollution)
→ NEVER "a/an". NEVER a plural -s. Go to STEP 2.

YES → go to STEP 2.

STEP 2 – GENERIC (the class as a whole) or SPECIFIC (this one)?

GENERIC plural countable → ZERO "Governments should invest in railways."
uncountable → ZERO "Education reduces poverty."
→ then go to STEP 4 for the exceptions.

SPECIFIC → STEP 3.

STEP 3 – FIRST mention or LATER mention?

LATER (or identifiable another way) → "the"

Identifiable if ANY of these is true:

- | | | |
|-----------------------|----------------------------|---------------------|
| • second mention | • an "of"-phrase follows | the impact of X |
| • a defining relative | • a superlative or ordinal | the highest figure |
| • unique in context | • a rate/proportion noun | the proportion of X |

FIRST → singular countable → "a/an"

plural countable → ZERO

uncountable → ZERO

STEP 4 – Is it on the KEEP-list?

the government • the environment • the media • the economy • the internet •
the public • the police • the climate (full list on the error card)
→ "the", even when generic. This step overrides STEP 2.

The five slots that account for most of what you actually get wrong:

1. **the + NOUN + of + NOUN** almost always takes **the** — *the number of students, the impact of technology, the role of government*. That is most of a Task 1 opening.
2. Superlatives and ordinals take **the** — but not after a possessive: *its highest level*.
3. **Generic plural is zero however long the modifier**. *Young people in rural areas are...*, not *The young people...*
4. Percentages and dates take **no** article — *in 2010, 20 per cent of students* — but *the percentage of students, the 1990s*.
5. **Second mention takes the**. *A congestion charge was introduced in 2003. The charge raised £2bn.*
Free accuracy, and it buys you cohesion too.

10. SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

The traps that actually catch you:

Subject	Verb	Note
people	<i>people are · people depend**</i>	already plural, never <i>peoples</i>
the government	<i>the government has**</i>	<i>the government have**</i> is fine in British English — leave it alone
the number of X	<i>is</i>	<i>The number of students is rising.</i>
a number of X	<i>are</i>	<i>A number of studies have shown...</i>
each / every + noun	<i>is / has</i>	<i>Each of the three regions has its own authority.</i>
information / advice / research / evidence	<i>is / shows</i>	<i>Recent research shows...</i>
the majority / proportion of X	agrees with X	<i>The majority of students live at home.</i>
a verb inside a relative clause	agrees with its own subject	<i>A child who spends three hours online reads less.</i>

Your errors

- ✗ **Peoples are depend** on public transport → ✓ **People depend** on public transport
- ✗ Technology **play** an important role → ✓ Technology **plays** an important role
- ✗ He **do not** agree → ✓ He **does not** agree
- ✗ The number of students **have** risen → ✓ The number of students **has** risen
- ✗ Each of the regions **have** its own budget → ✓ Each of the regions **has** its own budget
- ✗ Every student **need** support → ✓ Every student **needs** support
- ✗ Recent **researches show** → ✓ Recent **research shows**
- ✗ **Informations are** widely available → ✓ **Information is** widely available
- ✗ The evidence **suggest** otherwise → ✓ The evidence **suggests** otherwise
- ✗ A child who **spend** three hours online → ✓ A child who **spends** three hours online
- ✗ The government **are decide** to act → ✓ The government **has decided** to act

11. PUNCTUATION THAT COSTS MARKS

Punctuation is scored **inside grammar**, not as presentation. A comma splice damages two clauses at once, so it costs you two sentences, not one.

The comma splice — and its three fixes

Two complete sentences joined by a bare comma. Both your first languages encourage it: Arabic builds by chaining, French builds long.

Fix 1 — full stop. Safe, free, always available. **Fix 2 — semicolon.** Only when the two halves are tightly paired. **Fix 3 — subordinator** (*because · although · while · since · whereas*). **Prefer this one:** it is the only repair that converts a punctuation error into a complex structure. Every splice in your draft is a complex sentence you failed to build.

- ✗ *Public transport in the capital is heavily subsidised, this has kept fares low for two decades, many commuters have therefore abandoned their cars.* ✓ *Because public transport in the capital is heavily subsidised, fares have stayed low for two decades, and many commuters have abandoned their cars.*
- ✗ *University fees have doubled since 2010, however the number of applicants has continued to rise, this suggests that cost is not the main barrier to entry.* ✓ *University fees have doubled since 2010. However, the number of applicants has continued to rise, which suggests that cost is not the main barrier to entry.*

△ *however · therefore · moreover · furthermore · nevertheless · thus · consequently* are **adverbs**. They cannot join two clauses. Full stop or semicolon before them, comma after.

Two more, both cheap

No comma before *that*. - ✗ *The report shows, that emissions have fallen.* → ✓ *The report shows that emissions have fallen.*

Comma after a fronted adverbial — anything you put before the main subject. - ✗ *In the first decade of the century car ownership doubled.* → ✓ *In the first decade of the century, car ownership doubled.* - ✗ *Although fees have risen applications continue to grow.* → ✓ *Although fees have risen, applications continue to grow.*

12. SENTENCE VARIETY — the 4 shapes

The same idea, four ways. No new vocabulary appears in any of them. This is what "range" means, and you already own all of it.

1 Simple

— one clause. Error-free by construction, and a legitimate instrument.

Online learning has widened access to higher education.

2 Compound

— two equal clauses joined by *and · but · so*.

Online learning has widened access to higher education, but many rural students still lack a reliable connection.

3 Complex

— one clause made to depend on the other by a subordinator.

Although online learning has widened access to higher education, many rural students still lack a reliable connection.

4 Complex with a fronted element

— the same, with something moved to the front for focus.

In rural areas, where connections remain unreliable, the access promised by online learning is largely theoretical.

Rotate the four. An essay of nothing but shape 3 reads as mechanical; an essay of nothing but shape 1 is capped however clean it is.

13. THE 6-STEP PROOFREAD

Last three minutes. Do **not** read for meaning — you will read what you meant, not what you wrote. Read for one error type at a time, in this order, because this is the order of what each one costs you.

1. **Every *the* (50 s).** Abstract noun, talked about in general, nothing attached after it? **Delete it** — unless it is on the keep-list.
2. **Every comma (50 s).** Cover the left half: is the right a complete sentence? Cover the right: is the left? Two complete sentences with a bare comma between them is a splice — repair with a subordinator if you can, a full stop if you cannot. Then check every *however* / *therefore* / *moreover*: full stop before it.
3. **Every bare singular noun (20 s).** No article, no possessive, no quantifier? It needs *a/an* or *the*. And anything in the frame **___ of ___** almost certainly takes *the*.
4. **Verbs (30 s).** Singular subject in the present simple — is the *-s* there, including inside relative clauses? Two bare verbs stacked (*are depend, do not works*)? A passive on an intransitive verb (*was happened, was risen*)?
5. **The nine uncountables + *people* (10 s).** Any of them carrying an *-s*? Delete it, then fix the verb behind it.
6. **Your two longest sentences only (20 s).** *Although...but*? Delete the *but*. *Despite* + clause? Rewrite. *which...it* / *who...them*? Delete the pronoun. Participle clause — is the word right after the comma the thing doing the participle? *Would* in an *if*-clause? Change it to the past simple.

The rule that makes all six work: in these three minutes you may delete and repair. You may not add. The clever sentence written at minute 39 is untested, and one faulty complex sentence re-instates the band-6 limiter you spent forty minutes avoiding.